

CENTRAL ASIA, EURASIA AND CONNECTIVITY

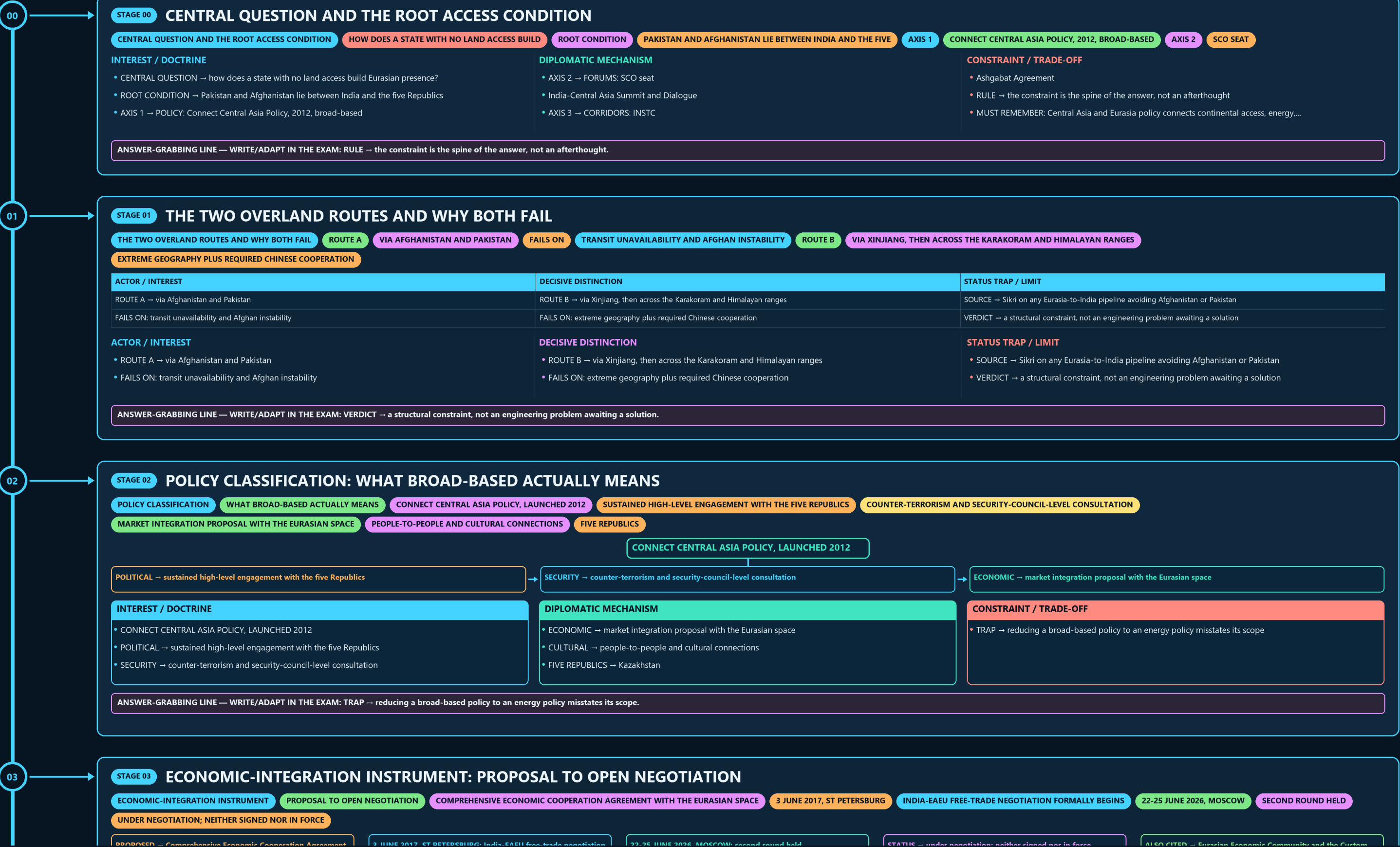
CENTRAL QUESTION AND THE → THE TWO OVERLAND ROUTES → POLICY CLASSIFICATION: WHAT BROAD-BASED → ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO → SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS → DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g4 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles



ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → reducing a broad-based policy to an energy policy misstates its scope.

03

STAGE 03 ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT: PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION

ECONOMIC-INTEGRATION INSTRUMENT PROPOSAL TO OPEN NEGOTIATION COMPREHENSIVE ECONOMIC COOPERATION AGREEMENT WITH THE EURASIAN SPACE 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG INDIA-EAEU FREE-TRADE NEGOTIATION FORMALLY BEGINS 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW SECOND ROUND HELD

UNDER NEGOTIATION; NEITHER SIGNED NOR IN FORCE

PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space

3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins

22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held

STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora

DATED OFFICIAL INSTRUMENT

- PROPOSED → Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement with the Eurasian space
- 3 JUNE 2017, ST PETERSBURG: India-EAEU free-trade negotiation formally begins

EVIDENTIARY LEVEL IT REACHES

- 22-25 JUNE 2026, MOSCOW: second round held
- STATUS → under negotiation; neither signed nor in force

STATUS / CLAIM LIMIT

- ALSO CITED → Eurasian Economic Community and the Custom Union as existing fora
- RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → cite the dated rounds as engagement, never as an achieved agreement.

04

STAGE 04 SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026

SCO PARTICIPATION MATRIX AS OF 3 AUGUST 2026 FULL MEMBERS (10) OBSERVERS (2) DIALOGUE PARTNERS PAKISTAN 2017 IRAN 2023 BELARUS 2024 1 SEPTEMBER 2025

|                            |             |              |
|----------------------------|-------------|--------------|
| OBSERVERS (2)              | Afghanistan | Mongolia     |
| DIALOGUE PARTNERS          | 15          |              |
| ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017 | Iran 2023   | Belarus 2024 |

ACTOR / INTEREST

- FULL MEMBERS (10)
- OBSERVERS (2)
- DIALOGUE PARTNERS

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- ACCESSIONS → Pakistan 2017
- Iran 2023
- Belarus 2024

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

- 1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → decision envisaging a single SCO Partner status
- PENDING → the enabling amendments had not entered into force
- TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: TRAP → Sikri's observer list is period-specific and must be dated when quoted.

05

STAGE 05 DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP

DEDICATED REGIONAL FORMAT AND ITS HONEST GAP 27 JANUARY 2022 FIRST INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT, HELD VIRTUALLY 6 JUNE 2025 FOURTH INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA DIALOGUE, NEW DELHI, FOREIGN-MINISTER LEVEL ENVISAGED PREPARING THE GROUND FOR A SECOND SUMMIT 16 OCTOBER 2025

THIRD MEETING OF SECURITY COUNCIL SECRETARIES AND NSAS, BISHKEK

27 JANUARY 2022 → first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually

6 JUNE 2025 → fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level

envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit

16 OCTOBER 2025 → third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek

31 AUGUST-1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

- 27 JANUARY 2022 → first India-Central Asia Summit, held virtually
- 6 JUNE 2025 → fourth India-Central Asia Dialogue, New Delhi, foreign-minister level
- envisaged preparing the ground for a second summit

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

- 16 OCTOBER 2025 → third meeting of Security Council Secretaries and NSAs, Bishkek
- 31 AUGUST-1 SEPTEMBER 2025 → SCO summit at Tianjin adopts the Tianjin Declaration
- Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26 with the next summit scheduled for Bishkek

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

- GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: GAP → no second leader-level summit recorded as held by 3 August 2026.

06

STAGE 06 CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT 13 MAY 2024 TEN-YEAR LONG-TERM CONTRACT, INDIA PORTS GLOBAL LIMITED WITH IRAN'S PORTS AND MARITIME ORGANISATION USD 120 MILLION ANNOUNCED EQUIPMENT INVESTMENT; LEVEL USD 250 MILLION

ANNOUNCED CREDIT WINDOW FOR MUTUALLY IDENTIFIED INFRASTRUCTURE

|                                                                            |                                                                                  |                                                                   |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ACTOR / INTEREST                                                           | DECISIVE DISTINCTION                                                             | STATUS TRAP / LIMIT                                               |
| 13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with | USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement            | LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance            |
| Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation                                     | USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure | RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels |

ACTOR / INTEREST

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

06

STAGE 06 CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT

CHABAHAR INSTRUMENT PRICED COMPONENT BY COMPONENT 13 MAY 2024 TEN-YEAR LONG-TERM CONTRACT, INDIA PORTS GLOBAL LIMITED WITH IRAN'S PORTS AND MARITIME ORGANISATION USD 120 MILLION ANNOUNCED EQUIPMENT INVESTMENT; LEVEL USD 250 MILLION ANNOUNCED CREDIT WINDOW FOR MUTUALLY IDENTIFIED INFRASTRUCTURE

| ACTOR / INTEREST                                                                                                                                                                   | DECISIVE DISTINCTION                                                                                                                                                                                                                | STATUS TRAP / LIMIT                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation                                                                  | USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement<br>USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure                                                                           | LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance<br>RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels                                                                          |
| ACTOR / INTEREST <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>13 MAY 2024 → ten-year long-term contract, India Ports Global Limited with Iran's Ports and Maritime Organisation</li></ul> | DECISIVE DISTINCTION <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>USD 120 MILLION → announced equipment investment; LEVEL: announcement</li><li>USD 250 MILLION → announced credit window for mutually identified infrastructure</li></ul> | STATUS TRAP / LIMIT <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>LEVEL → announced credit window, not disbursed finance</li><li>RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels</li></ul> |

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → announcement and delivery are different evidentiary levels.

07

STAGE 07 SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE

SANCTIONS EXPOSURE PATH AND ITS CONSEQUENCE 16 SEPTEMBER 2025 UNITED STATES STATE DEPARTMENT REVOKES THE 2018 WAIVER 29 SEPTEMBER 2025 REVOCATION TAKES EFFECT NON-EXPOSURE RUNS ONLY TO 26 APRIL 2026 BEYOND THAT DATE STATUS REQUIRES FRESH VERIFICATION

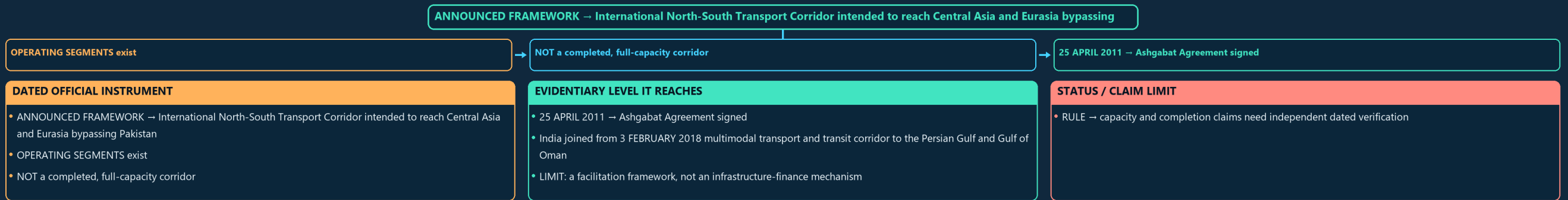


ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CONSEQUENCE → the Iran work-around becomes a financing question, not a map question.

08

STAGE 08 CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER

CORRIDOR STATUS LADDER ANNOUNCED FRAMEWORK INTERNATIONAL NORTH-SOUTH TRANSPORT CORRIDOR INTENDED TO REACH CENTRAL ASIA OPERATING SEGMENTS EXIST NOT A COMPLETED, FULL-CAPACITY CORRIDOR 25 APRIL 2011 ASHGABAT AGREEMENT SIGNED; INDIA JOINED FROM 3 FEBRUARY 2018 A FACILITATION FRAMEWORK, NOT AN INFRASTRUCTURE-FINANCE MECHANISM



ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: RULE → capacity and completion claims need independent dated verification.

09

STAGE 09 COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY THE REGION ABUTS MAJOR ASIAN POWERS AND WILL ALWAYS SUSTAINED DIPLOMACY THROUGH A SEAT, A DIALOGUE AND CORRIDOR RUSSIAN AND CHINESE PROXIMITY IS GREATER THAN INDIA'S ACCEPT CO-DETERMINED OUTCOMES RATHER THAN CLAIMING REGIONAL PRIMACY MIXED SCO MEMBERSHIP INCLUDES PAKISTAN THE FORUM SUSTAINS ENGAGEMENT; IT CANNOT RESOLVE TRANSIT ACCESS MULTI-ACTOR COMPETITION, EXPRESSLY NOT INDIAN DETERMINISM

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| INTEREST / DOCTRINE <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>PROBLEM → the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences</li><li>RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments</li><li>PROBLEM → Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's</li></ul> | DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy</li><li>PROBLEM → mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan</li><li>RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access</li></ul> | CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism</li><li>CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...</li></ul> |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

09

STAGE 09

COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

COMPETITIVE FIELD AND THE LIMITS OF INDIAN AGENCY

THE REGION ABUTS MAJOR ASIAN POWERS AND WILL ALWAYS

SUSTAINED DIPLOMACY THROUGH A SEAT, A DIALOGUE AND CORRIDOR

RUSSIAN AND CHINESE PROXIMITY IS GREATER THAN INDIA'S

ACCEPT CO-DETERMINED OUTCOMES RATHER THAN CLAIMING REGIONAL PRIMACY

MIXED SCO MEMBERSHIP INCLUDES PAKISTAN

THE FORUM SUSTAINS ENGAGEMENT; IT CANNOT RESOLVE TRANSIT ACCESS

MULTI-ACTOR COMPETITION, EXPRESSLY NOT INDIAN DETERMINISM

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

• PROBLEM → the region abuts major Asian powers and will always attract foreign presences

• RESPONSE: sustained diplomacy through a seat, a dialogue and corridor instruments

• PROBLEM → Russian and Chinese proximity is greater than India's

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

• RESPONSE: accept co-determined outcomes rather than claiming regional primacy

• PROBLEM → mixed SCO membership includes Pakistan

• RESPONSE: the forum sustains engagement; it cannot resolve transit access

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

• VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism

• CLOSE DISTINCTION: INSTC, Chabahar, Ashgabat Agreement, SCO and bilateral connectivity...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT → multi-actor competition, expressly not Indian determinism.

10

STAGE 10

FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST

FUNCTIONAL COOPERATION INSIDE STRATEGIC MISTRUST

INDIA AND CHINA SEEK ENERGY FROM THE SAME SOURCES

THAT COMPETITION ONLY BENEFITS THE ENERGY PRODUCERS

SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION

DEVELOP AN UNDERSTANDING ON ENERGY WITH CHINA

COOPERATION ON ONE FUNCTION ALONGSIDE UNRESOLVED STRATEGIC MISTRUST

THE WIDER INDIA-CHINA STRATEGIC RELATIONSHIP BELONGS TO TOPIC 03

AVOIDS THE CRUDE CHOICE BETWEEN PURE RIVALRY AND NAIVE

| ACTOR / INTEREST                                                       | DECISIVE DISTINCTION                                                              | STATUS TRAP / LIMIT                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources        | COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust | EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia... |
| EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers           | BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03       |                                                                                         |
| SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China | USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership          |                                                                                         |

ACTOR / INTEREST

• COMPETITION → India and China seek energy from the same sources

• EFFECT → that competition only benefits the energy producers

• SIKRI'S RECOMMENDATION → develop an understanding on energy with China

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

• COEXISTENCE → cooperation on one function alongside unresolved strategic mistrust

• BOUNDARY → the wider India-China strategic relationship belongs to topic 03

• USE → avoids the crude choice between pure rivalry and naive partnership

STATUS TRAP / LIMIT

• EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Map India-Iran-Russia-Central Asia.

11

STAGE 11

ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND

ANSWER SPINE FOR A CENTRAL ASIA DEMAND

STATE THE ABSENCE OF DIRECT LAND ACCESS BEFORE LISTING

POLICY, FORUMS AND CORRIDORS, EACH WITH ONE DATED INSTRUMENT

PRICE SANCTIONS EXPOSURE, THE UNHELD SUMMIT AND THE OPEN

CONVERT GOODWILL INTO RELIABLE ACCESS AS THE GRADED VERDICT

OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly

CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

INTEREST / DOCTRINE

• OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

• BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

DIPLOMATIC MECHANISM

• TEST → price sanctions exposure, the unheld summit and the open negotiation honestly

• CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing

CONSTRAINT / TRADE-OFF

• OPEN → state the absence of direct land access before listing any opportunity

• BUILD → policy, forums and corridors, each with one dated instrument at its level

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: CLOSE → convert goodwill into reliable access as the graded verdict, predicting nothing.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

THE BROAD MULTILATERAL BODY THROUGH WHICH INDIA ENGAGES CENTRAL

INDIA-CENTRAL ASIA SUMMIT AND DIALOGUE

THE MORE DIRECT

INSTC AND CHABAHAR PORT

CONNECTIVITY FRAMEWORKS UNDER CONTINUING

INDIA-USBKISTAN BILATERAL BRIEF (AS ON APRIL 2026)

THE MOST RECENT

OPTIONAL DOCTRINE AND INSTRUMENT DEPTH

• SCO: the broad multilateral body through which India engages Central

• India-Central Asia Summit and Dialogue: the more direct,

• INSTC and Chabahar port: connectivity frameworks under continuing

• India-Uzbekistan bilateral brief (as on April 2026): the most recent

STATUS, DATE AND FIGURE LIMIT

• India-Eurasian Economic Union free-trade negotiation: the current form

• Direct PYQ boundary case (2024 Q10): the question asks for a "critical"

• CAUTION: Boundary case — Afghanistan's ambiguous status: Afghanistan sits at the

• CAUTION: Boundary case — India-China energy cooperation despite rivalry: Sikri's

COMPARATIVE DIPLOMATIC NUANCE

• CAUTION: Boundary case — SCO membership without privileged access: India's SCO

• CAUTION: No unilateral connectivity solution exists: both direct land routes

• CAUTION: SCO engagement is diluted by mixed membership: India's participation

• CAUTION: Energy-source competition with China risks negative-sum outcomes

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.